commanded in German.

The woman stepped forward slowly, knees bent low to the ground like a dog approaching a perceived threat.

“Look at the patch on your apron!” the Lagerführer said. “The stitching on it has come undone, and one corner is loose. How can anyone read it?” Then, like a flash of lightning, *smack*. She struck the woman across the face with a force that made her fall back.

Léa recoiled, bringing her hand to her face, as if she had also been struck and felt her skin burning. Lagerführer Klein straightened her dress, pulled her shoulders back and raised her chin as if to reassert her rightful control. “Fix that patch now before I dock your wages!”

The woman’s cheek flamed red, and her gaze, for an instant, fell on Léa, before she turned and ran up the stairs.

“Go on, the rest of you Polish pigs, get back to work!” Lagerführer Klein said, continuing up the stairs.

The Lagerführer’s actions and words felt like a blade in Léa’s chest, tearing through bone and muscle, ripping her heart apart. She didn’t understand why these women were treated so cruelly. Would the same be done to her and Rose?

“Will my sister and I be given patches to sew onto our aprons?” she asked.

The Lagerführer turned, her icy-blue eyes narrowing as she stared at Léa. “You’re French. Those patches are for the *Untermenschen*.” Her mouth tightened. “Those women must be set apart and isolated. The patches allow everyone, at a glance, to know who they are and how to treat them.”

“Oh.” Léa turned away, fighting off the nausea, helplessness and shock that her body struggled to absorb. How could she ease these women’s pain and shame? She didn’t know, but she had to find out.

“I’ll show you to the bunk bed you will share on the second floor.”

Léa looked at Rose, her face frozen in fear. And a voice inside her whispered, *Find a way to make up for it.* It was what Maître Mallon had told her to do. And then her mother’s words came to her. *Keep a good heart.* With a new resolve, she lifted her skirt and followed the Lagerführer up the stairs.